

## Story1

The lights buzzed as Laura blinked awake. She was in a private room at Saint Joseph's hospital, but her mind felt foggy. A nurse walked in and handed her a tiny bundle. "Time for his feeding, she said, already leaving.

Laura unwrapped the blanket and froze. This wasn't her son. Her baby had pale blue eyes, not this little boy's deep brown. Panic rose in her chest as the boy began crying, hungry. She pushed the call button but no one answered. His wails grew frantic. Acting on instinct, she lifted her gown and guided him to her breast. His cries quieted as he fed. Laura stroked his soft hair, his delicate ear. This child needed her. Her panic faded. She burped and changed him, letting him sleep in her arms. She knew she should tell someone about the mistake but couldn't bear to give him up yet. Her thoughts of home felt distant.

She held the boy, breathing his milky smell, drifting in and out of sleep throughout the remaining hours of the long night. Having fed him when she woke up, she grew attached to the little stranger in her arms. She spent a blissful few hours getting to know the little boy, his expressions, sounds and gestures. Her maternal instincts had kicked into full force and she felt as bonded to this little brown eyed baby as she did to her own newborn.

A nurse came in the next morning. "How's our little guy? Laura hesitated, unwilling to give up this captivating stranger. The nurse peered at the sleeping baby."Oh dear. A mistake. I'm sorry. We'll return him right away." Laura felt anguished at losing this child who wasn't hers. But beneath that, relief. Her own son needed her. The nurse took the baby, apologizing constantly.

Laura cried inconsolably as the nurse walked away with the little boy in her arms. She begged the nurse to give her a few more minutes but the nurse insisted he be returned to the rightful mother immediately. Laura's heart shattered into pieces as she watched the nurse disappear down the hallway with the little boy.

She knew she had to go home to her own newborn, but couldn't stop thinking about the little brown eyed baby who she had cared for through the night. Her heart broke at the thought of him crying for her as she had cried for him. She worried if his real mother's milk would satisfy him after he had fed from her. She knew it was foolish but she felt as if he was her own. A piece of her heart had left with that little baby.

Laura stayed awake all night worrying about the little boy. Every time she dozed off she would imagine him crying inconsolably as she returned him to his real mother. She tossed and turned, unable to shake the feeling of dread in her stomach. Her breasts leaked as her hormones raged, longing to feed a baby. She felt empty and alone. A deep sorrow had come over her unlike anything she had ever known. She cried out in anguish, clutching her pillow, wishing it was that little baby she held instead.

A taxi took Laura home at the crack of dawn. Her emotions seesawed between guilt at leaving the little boy and excitement to see her own son. Love for her

child won out. Her husband opened the door, face lighting up. Laura walked in, flooded with relief and joy to be with family again. But part of her would always remain with that brown-eyed boy, the child who was hers, if only for a short, bittersweet time.

Laura slept for the next couple of days, recovering from the difficult delivery and emotional turmoil of the past couple of days. Her mind kept drifting back to the little boy. She hoped he was back with his own mother, being cared for and loved. She felt a pang of sadness, knowing she would never see him again, never know what became of him. Every time her baby woke for a feeding, she gazed into his pale blue eyes and was reminded of the deep brown ones that still lingered in her memory.

Laura's baby's fussiness concerned her the first night home. He seemed inconsolable for hours. She tried everything to soothe him but he continued to cry. She wondered if he sensed her distraction and worry for the little brown-eyed boy. She felt a rush of guilt, and held her baby close, showering him with love and attention. Eventually he slept, and Laura dozed off still dressed and sitting up in bed, her baby snuffling in her arms. She woke up frequently during the night to check on him. She was worried history may repeat itself and she would wake up to find another baby in her arms. She knew it was irrational but the experience had shaken her up quite a bit.

When Laura woke a few hours later, her breasts were full and aching again. As she lifted her son to nurse, her milk let down suddenly gushed out in a rush. Her son sputtered, unable to keep up with the flow. Concerned, Laura switched him to the other side, but it was the same. Her milk kept flowing faster than he could drink. She worried it might be due to the extra stimulation from feeding the other baby the previous days. Laura called the pediatrician, who had her come into the office immediately.

After examining Laura and the baby, the doctor determined her milk supply had temporarily increased due to feeding two babies instead of one. The doctor suggested manually expressing some milk after feedings to relieve pressure, and the issue should resolve within a couple of days. Laura followed the doctor's advice, though she still felt engorged and uncomfortable at times. But her supply did start to level off, and her son gained weight. A week later at his first checkup, the doctor declared him perfectly healthy. Laura felt deep relief to have her baby thriving and the feeding issues resolved. Yet still, thoughts of the little brown-eyed baby tugged at her.

Laura struggled with her emotions in the following months. On the surface, she was overjoyed with her new baby, but part of her heart felt like it was missing. Her husband was confused by her occasional withdrawals into sadness. She couldn't explain to him this secret ache in her soul. Every time she gazed into her son's blue eyes she thought of the little boy with brown eyes. She dreamed of him at night, happy and cared for in his mother's arms.

Her son grew into a chubby, smiley infant who brought her immense joy. But

in her weakest moments, Laura allowed herself to wonder about the little boy. She hoped his brown eyes lit up like her baby's did when he saw her. She hoped his mother held him tight and never stopped appreciating the gift she'd been given. She knew, in that short time together, her life had intertwined with a stranger's in a way she'd never forget.

Though the pain lessened over time, the memory remained. Her secret experience had opened her eyes to the fragility of life and deepened her appreciation for the blessings she had been given. She gazed at her son, now a playful toddler, and felt gratitude for the joy he brought her each day. Her life felt more complete than she had ever imagined, yet still, she kept the little brown-eyed boy tucked away in her heart - a symbol of the wonder and possibility each new life holds.

-----The End-----

## Story2

The clock struck midnight as Lily stumbled through the sterile corridors of the maternity ward. Exhausted and disoriented, she clutched her chest, trying to steady her racing heart. The sleepless nights, the cries of newborns, and the overwhelming smell of antiseptic had wrapped her mind in a fog.

As Lily walked past the rows of hospital rooms, she noticed other women in various stages of sleep, their pale faces shadowed with exhaustion. Each room seemed to contain its own unique symphony of wailing infants, creating a disorienting chorus that reverberated through the halls.

Lily paused outside Room 329, her room, and glanced inside. The sight that greeted her eyes sent a jolt of confusion through her veins. There, lying in the crib next to her bed, was a baby that was unmistakably not her own. Panic welled up inside her, but it was quickly replaced by an inexplicable sense of happiness.

Without questioning her instincts, she entered the room, picked up the unknown baby, and cradled it in her arms. Its tiny body felt warm against her skin, and although she was aware deep down that this was not her child, she couldn't help but feel an inexplicable bond forming.

The door creaked open, and a nurse appeared, her tired eyes widening in shock. "Ma'am, what are you doing?" she asked, her voice a mix of concern and confusion. "That's not your baby, that belongs to the woman in Room 331."

Lily blinked, her mind slowly piecing together the reality of the situation. The fog that had clouded her senses began to lift, and she realized her mistake. A wave of embarrassment washed over her, and she carefully placed the baby back in its crib.

"I'm so sorry," she stammered, her cheeks flushing with embarrassment. "I don't know what came over me."

The nurse sighed and gave her a sympathetic smile. "It happens sometimes, especially in the early hours of the morning when new mothers are sleep deprived. I'll take care of returning the baby to its rightful mother."

Lily watched as the nurse cradled the baby in her arms and left the room. She felt a strange mixture of relief and sadness flood her being. Although she had mistakenly believed the child was hers for a brief moment, a part of her couldn't help but feel a sense of loss.

As she made her way back to her own room, Lily couldn't shake off the strange encounter. It was as if a switch had been flipped inside her, awakening something she didn't know existed. The exhaustion that had weighed her down seemed to dissipate, replaced by a newfound energy.

In her room, Lily noticed another mother sitting in a chair by the window. The woman's eyes were red from crying, her face etched with worry. Lily approached her cautiously, somehow sensing a connection between them.

"Are you alright?" she asked softly, her voice filled with genuine concern.

The woman looked up, tears welling in her eyes. "I don't know," she whispered, her voice trembling. "My baby... something doesn't feel right. I fear I may have made a mistake."

Suddenly, Lily felt an inexplicable surge of empathy. She reached out and took the woman's hand, feeling an immediate connection. "I understand," she assured her. "I experienced something similar just moments ago. Let's help each other."

The two women spent the rest of the night talking, sharing their fears and uncertainties. They discovered they had more in common than they could imagine. Both had endured difficult pregnancies and had been plagued with doubts about their abilities as mothers.

As dawn broke, the two women made a decision that would forever alter the course of their lives. They approached the nurses' station, arm in arm, and made a simple request: to switch their babies. The confusion and chaos that ensued were met with determination and unwavering trust.

Within hours, the paperwork was completed, and Lily found herself cradling the baby she had mistakenly believed was hers. It was an unconventional arrangement, but neither woman questioned it. They had found solace in each other and had chosen to embrace the uncertainty that had brought them together.

Days turned into weeks, and as Lily cared for her newfound child, she marveled at the newfound joy that filled her life. She couldn't explain the overwhelming happiness that radiated from her core, but she knew deep down that she had made the right decision.

As the years went by, Lily and the woman she had met in the hospital watched their children grow side by side. They became more than friends; they became

a support system for each other, navigating the challenges of motherhood with unwavering love and understanding.

Sometimes, in the quiet moments of the night, Lily would look into her child's eyes and think about the uncanny mix-up that had brought them together. She knew that fate had intervened that night, guiding her towards a child who was destined to be hers. And in that inexplicable happiness, Lily found the true meaning of motherhood.

Years later, Lily's newfound child, whom she named Grace, was enrolled in an elite art school. The walls of the gallery were adorned with the breathtaking masterpieces created by the students. Grace's artwork stood out, captivating the viewers with its intricate details and vibrant colors.

One evening, as Lily gazed at one of Grace's paintings, a voice from behind her whispered, "She has your talent, Lily." Lily turned to find an elderly gentleman with kind eyes and a warm smile.

"Do I know you?" she asked, puzzled.

The man chuckled. "No, my dear, but I knew your mother. She was an extraordinary artist, just like you."

Lily's heart skipped a beat, and a rush of memories flooded her mind. She remembered her own mother, who had passed away when she was just a child. She had always wondered if she had inherited her mother's artistic abilities.

"Is it possible?" Lily asked, her voice quivering with emotion.

The man nodded. "There's no doubt in my mind. You and Grace share the same gift."

Tears welled up in Lily's eyes as she looked at Grace's artwork once again. It was as if a missing piece of her life had finally been found. She had always felt a connection to art, but now she knew that her love for creativity was a part of her heritage.

Lily and Grace spent hours discussing art and sharing their passion for painting. They embarked on a journey together, exploring different techniques and experimenting with different mediums. Their bond grew stronger with each stroke of the brush, and they found solace in the immense beauty they created together.

As the years went by, Lily's art career flourished, and she became renowned for her unique style. She held exhibitions all over the world, showcasing her talent and spreading her message of love and unity through art.

Through it all, Lily couldn't help but feel a deep gratitude for the mix-up in the maternity ward that had led her to Grace. It was a twist of fate that had shaped their lives, connecting them in ways they never could have imagined.

And as Lily stood beside her daughter, basking in the admiration of their shared passion, she knew that the true meaning of motherhood went beyond biology.

It was about love, connection, and embracing life's unexpected turns. And in that realization, Lily found the fulfillment she had always longed for.

Years later, Lily's artwork was being celebrated in a retrospective exhibition. The gallery was filled with people from all walks of life, who marveled at the incredible beauty and depth of her creations. As Lily stood amongst her masterpieces, a woman approached her with tears streaming down her face.

"You're Lily, aren't you?" the woman asked, her voice trembling with emotion.

Lily nodded, her heart skipping a beat. "Yes, I am."

"I just wanted to tell you how much your art has meant to me," the woman continued. "Your paintings have brought so much joy, healing, and inspiration into my life. Thank you for sharing your gift with the world."

Tears welled up in Lily's eyes as she embraced the woman. It was a moment of pure, unadulterated connection. In that moment, Lily realized the true impact her art had on others. It wasn't just about her own personal expression; it was about touching the souls of those who encountered her creations.

As the years went by, Lily continued to create art that touched people's hearts. She became a mentor to aspiring artists, sharing her knowledge and wisdom with a new generation. And through it all, she never forgot the twist of fate that had led her to Grace and the incredible journey they had embarked on together.

In the end, it wasn't just about the mix-up in the maternity ward or the artistic talents they shared. It was about the profound connection between two souls, brought together by chance and destined to impact the world in their own unique way. And in that realization, Lily found the true fulfillment she had always longed for.

With each stroke of her brush, Lily painted not only her own story but the stories of all those whose lives she had touched. The gallery walls whispered her name as people from all walks of life gazed in awe at the tapestry of emotions she had woven through her art.

As Lily immersed herself in her creative process, she couldn't help but reflect on the journey that had led her to this moment. The mix-up in the maternity ward had been the catalyst that ignited her passion for art and connected her with Grace. It was a twist of fate that had given her the courage to pursue her dreams and embrace her true calling.

But it wasn't just about her own success. Lily yearned to make a difference in the world beyond the walls of the gallery. She knew that art had the power to heal, inspire, and unite people from all walks of life.

Guided by this mission, Lily began collaborating with communities in need, using her art as a tool for social change. She partnered with local organizations to create murals that told stories of resilience and hope. Through workshops

and mentorship programs, she empowered individuals to find their own creative voices and reimagine their realities.

The impact of Lily's work resonated far and wide. Her murals became a source of inspiration, sparking conversations about social justice and equality. The communities she worked with saw firsthand the transformative power of art, as individuals discovered new ways of expression and harnessed their creativity to effect change.

Lily's art became a driving force in the fight for justice and equality. She used her platform to advocate for the voiceless and shine a light on the issues that often went unnoticed. Through her collaborations and exhibitions, she brought together people from diverse backgrounds, bridging the gaps that divided them and fostering understanding.

The legacy of Lily's work lived on, even as she grew older. Her art continued to inspire future generations, as young artists looked to her as a role model and mentor. She dedicated her later years to nurturing emerging talents, ensuring that the power of art would continue to shape the world long after she was gone.

As Lily's story came full circle, she marveled at how a simple mix-up in a maternity ward had shaped her life in ways she could never have imagined. She had found love, purpose, and fulfillment, not only through motherhood but also through the transformative power of art.

As the final strokes of her last masterpiece adorned the canvas, Lily felt a profound sense of peace. She knew that her journey, like her art, would continue to inspire and touch lives long after she had departed. And in that realization, she smiled, knowing that she had made a lasting impact on the world through her beautiful creations.

-----The End-----

### Story3

There is no sound in the world quite like a baby crying. Late at night, on the chilly outskirts of Prague, in the maternity ward of an unfamiliar hospital, its howl rang through her head like the warble of a siren. Lying in bed half-asleep, the woman was attuned to the cries of her own newborn, and the addition of strange infants wails threatened to stir in her a nameless fear. As the longing grew more desperate, she snuggled him closer to her chest. An unsettling sense then crept upon her: the child in her arms buried his face in her chest, giving no indication that he was the siren that haunted the room. The dimmed light revealed a scrawled name: "Marie."

Marie pricked her ears in the darkness, her mind racing to comprehend her reality. Slowly, her senses sharpened, and eventually, she began to decipher the airiness of the room. To her utter amazement and bewilderment, she discovered the source of the crying was not her baby but another who rested only a few feet away in the neighboring bed. The cries were layered, echoing, and overlapping;

some seemed distant and others as if they were the sole disturbance in the quiet expanse of the room.

As the minutes passed, Marie noticed that each cry seemed imbued with an otherworldly power, as if it could influence the very fabric of reality. Translucent curtains separated one mother from the other, delicate membranes of privacy, like the fragile amniotic sac concealing a secret world. In this shrouded space, the wails grew in intensity until her ears ached with the feel of the unending sound. The unknown woman on the other side of the curtain was hardly distinguishable: a vaguely human shape that fell deeper into her bed, seemingly adrift in a sea of anxiety and trepidation.

The room held numerous sleeping mothers, each with their own newborn and each cradled by a protective presence. A shifting aura settled over the space, a soft and empathetic energy that murmured like an invisible sea. A motherly force bound them together, intertwined by the power of life, creation, and the unbreakable bond between a parent and child.

Then, scarcely registered as more than a fleeting peripheral vision, unseen hands lifted quivering flesh, wrapped it in a soft cloth, and whisked her baby away.

In that instant, perception became difficult: an inextricable yearning took hold of Marie's heart, its tendrils pinching and tightening her chest. A profound sense of separation weighed on her, as though her existence had been forever stilled, her ties to the world shelved on that neighboring bed. She wondered how she could feel the presence of another even when their existence seemed unclear, obscured by the swells and eons of ruptured emotions between them.

Time seemed to slow and grow heavy, each second lasting what felt like a lifetime. Marie lay there stewing in curiosity, contemplating her own place in the world and the impact of this newborn life within it. Marie imagined herself and the other mother entwined within some invisible snarl, a fabric that spanned outwards towards the concept of kin, weaving thickets of connection through the generations. How peculiar it was, she thought, to be connected by blood to an infant you could barely see—at the same moment as you felt a near-cordial unity with its mother awakened by a shared experience. She mused on the repletion of existence, about the many different languages people used to communicate such a distillation of desire.

Her thoughts wandered to her journey to the hospital, tainted by a sense of foreboding she could not shake. The streets of Prague had felt cold and oppressive, the hospital's towering, monolithic architecture only enhancing her sense of unease. This strange institution had become the birthplace of her child, and yet, it seemed to hold far greater secrets than her own unspoken fears. The knowledge that this place held the key to something irrevocable and arcane seemed to hang heavily in the air, saturating the atmosphere with the subtle stench of magic.

As Marie lay there, pondering her strange situation, the room seemed to shift and warp. The moonlight bathed the walls and cast a pearly aura that made

the environment feel more ethereal, mysterious, and full of wonder. Though her previous unease lingered, she couldn't help but become entranced by the beauty of the space around her; this sanctuary for new life shimmering with the potential of every new mother and child.

Sleep came uneasily to her, troubled by thoughts of motherhood and the uncertain future. Some hours before, she had been mistaken for another patient possessing the same first name. The nurse held her hearty and long-suffering sigh in reply, her patient eyes rolling across the steadily filling chambers of the ward. Marie, a distinguished linguist from a far-off university and pregnant by a whirlwind love affair, suddenly found her tongue dipped in ice. Dumbstruck, she was whisked away to the maternity ward without ceremony, her waxy protests lodging themselves in her throat.

The hospital's sanctum held the weight of many sleepless nights. It was a place where the gently prodding hands of a clock ticked away without resistance—one moment weighed equally against its peers. In the nighttime, shadows lengthened, fingertips of darkness reaching for the newborns: an invisible hand stealing her child from her. Perhaps it was this acute horror of motherhood that drew her so intensely to him, her unfathomable need to protect that small, precious life. This urge manifested itself in the whispered lullabies that formed on her tongue, the cradling of her arms in a motion as old as time itself.

A faint sound tweaked at her ear: the uneven sound of footsteps. The fabric of the curtains rustled. Drifting through this half-veiled dream, she stood to peek through the silken membrane. She felt a cry trapped within her but quieted the thought. If she were noticed, something terrible might happen, though she knew not what. Instinct told her that to witness the procession of silent figures through the room was a responsibility bestowed upon her, that to comprehend the weight of it would taint her somehow. Her curiosity tugged at her sensibilities, though, and so she remained rooted to the spot, mesmerized by the ethereal figures that drifted about the room.

Nurses walked the length of the floor, a huddle of bright neons and hushed voices. The mother with a silvery voice lay in bed, one leg beneath the bedsheets and the other dangling over the edge. She held her infant tenderly, as though he were not a baby, but a treasure. Marie was struck by this sight—to her, the women and their babies seemed like constellations. Fat bundles of stardust swaddled in textiles of sky-blue, daisy-yellow, or April-green.

The scene before her painting a surreal panorama of life's totality, held in the bonds of friendship and blood, illuminated by the soft glow of lantern light. The air tasted honeyed, the sweet mixture of milk and warmth permeating throughout the room. It comforted her, a solace she desperately needed in this ocean of uncertainty.

Unaware that she had held her breath, Marie exhaled softly. She leaned her head against the cold stone wall and tried to lure sleep back into her body. Her heartbeat stabilized against the rhythm of the overhead clock's gentle tick-

ing. She closed her eyes against her better judgment, inviting slumber's tender embrace.

When she awoke, the hospital smelled of white lilies. A bouquet of them stood on the counter next to her bed, a brilliant contrast to the muted grays and dull whites of the room. The woman with the silvery voice stood by her side, her face bright with a maternal glow.

"Good morning," she said with a strange sparkle in her eyes.

Reluctant to speak, Marie locked eyes with the other mother and acknowledged her with a terse nod. She felt a displacement deep within her, an odd blend of unease and comfort in motherhood. It had never been her dream to cradle a child in her arms. And yet, the weight of the baby soothed the jagged edges of her heart.

"Is that your baby?" the woman asked.

Marie stared at the child in her arms. It must have been, for no one had taken him from her in the night. She nodded once more, although she was not quite certain.

"Do you have a name for him?" the other woman asked, her voice shimmering like silk on a windy day.

Marie hesitated, her eyes combing over the baby's features. She thought of all the words, the delicately spun names that might rest upon his skin like a downy plumage. Would she ever have a chance to wrap her arms around a baby again? To feel a connection that outlasted the stars and the clocks that ticked endlessly towards oblivion? She wanted to name the child after her father, but a whisper of doubt clouded the thought. Her grip on the baby loosened, and she handed him to the other mother. Let the experienced woman hold him instead; she feared her touch would betray a secret she could hardly comprehend.

"A name?" the woman repeated, her grip tightening on the child as if what Marie had just said had been a figment of their imagination.

Marie looked up to meet her eyes. For a fleeting moment, she grasped all the ways life could be entangled: how one soul could be woven around another, a kaleidoscope of figures spilling into the future. "Autolycus."

The woman stared at her for a moment and then nodded. "A lovely name—strong arms, you have there."

The door to the room burst open, and a nurse swept in, her arms filled with white lilies. Oblivious to the pair, she clucked her tongue in irritation and placed the bouquet onto the stone floor, muttering something about insensitive delivery boys.

Marie hesitated, the truth lodged in her throat. She wanted to explain, to find the words to capture the strange howling of the night. But she couldn't. All

that remained was the baby's tiny face, the echo of tiny lungs huffing and crying out in the night, and a sensation she could not put words to.

The hospital's pallor soon seemed less gray, tinged with the bright, airy scent of lilies. Marie left that room an hour later, cradling her son, or rather, her perceived son. The adoption process went smoothly—she claimed the father to be a mystery.

Years passed quietly for her and Autolycus, the name clinging to him as if the air around them secreted an arcane substance that bound them together. Marie wondered if her life had been spun by an unseen hand or if it was the discovery of inexplicable truths that altered the essence of the world around her. When Marie looked back upon that disorienting night, she realized she had become part of some other mother's world, that her soul had merged with that woman with the silvery voice, birthing a new life despite the haze of uncertainty.

Time, she realized, was a fabric spun of mutual longing, and within its endless loops and whorls lay the inextricably tangled threads of life, destiny, and unspoken connections. In her heart, she knew that her Baby Autolycus, the product of an inexplicable and enigmatic night, was the embodiment of the ultimate connection between herself and the unknown mother, an unbreakable bond woven into their very souls.

-----The End-----

#### Story4

It wasn't my first baby, but it was my first night in the hospital at Hvidovre.

I'm talking about it now because my husband doesn't believe me and our two other children don't, either. None of them were there at the start.

I'd bled heavily and we'd been put under observation. I was sweating that colossal sweat which comes washing out of you postpartum, the sweat of childbirth. I was all on my own in the room. It was so small and scribbly, like a cracked casing.

The child was sleeping in the cot. I'd fed her formula from a cup. My milk hadn't come in yet. Apart from the bleeding, the birth had gone well, but I couldn't sleep. Through the window I could see a maze of low-cut hedges, and behind them in the semidarkness a hospital building identical to the one I was in.

No, there was no tone in me. There was no call. A gray and foggy light descended upon me. It was the early morning. I was thirsty. I remembered an old folktale in which a woman cuts off her breasts. Then I thought about Mutter Pappenheimer, a beggar woman in Germany, who had her breasts torn off with a pair of tongs in 1600. The hospital was still. The hospital gown was unfathomably long; it hung down between my legs. My strange, distant feet walked. The child lay like a shadow in the cot as I opened the door. The door made a sweeping sound. Farther along the corridor I could see another woman

in a hospital gown like mine; she dragged her feet, too. She had messed-up hair and a wild, inward look in her eyes. She clutched her phone.

It hurt to walk, but it wasn't as if I'd never been there before. I could feel how the warm blood slid out of me like liquid from a test tube. In the patients' kitchen I gulped from the juice carton.

"That's my juice. It was the woman from the corridor.

"No, actually it's the whole ward's juice, I replied, and gulped some more.

She studied me.

"Did you see my kid? she asked.

"No, I don't think so, I answered. "Is he asleep? "I think so.

I nodded and wiped my mouth on my sleeve. Out in the corridor under the strip lighting a second woman in a hospital gown, bandy-legged after giving birth, came slowly toward us. Her face was completely blank.

"Did you see my kid? she asked, staring, and opened her mouth strangely, as if she were about to be swabbed. I smiled. I felt an afterpain, and bled again. The sanitary towel grew thick between my legs, like a pair of rolled-up tennis socks.

"Did you see her? she asked again.

I backed into my room and closed the door cautiously. There was a dusklike murk, silence. The child's fragrance filled the room. I went over to her cot. We'd brought our own duvet and a little baby hat, but they say baby hats aren't necessary, that's only in movies. The cot was empty. I snatched up the duvet; it was still warm, but there was no child. I ran out into the corridor. My stitches pulled. "My baby's gone! I yelled.

A sleepy nurse was eating sponge cake in the duty room. She turned toward me, unalarmed.

"She was lying in her cot only a moment ago! I said.

"Let's go and have a look, shall we? She got to her feet, brushed some crumbs from her uniform.

"Come on, she said, and took my arm. "You look pale. Have you remembered your liquids?

"I drank some juice, I said, and let myself be led.

In the corridor, three women in hospital gowns wandered, bandy-legged.

"Are they always up at this time, the women? I asked.

"Yes, it can be quite lively between three and four, the nurse said. The uniform gave her a uniboob, and she wore a badge with a four-leaf clover in red and gold. Stepping into the room, I broke out in a sweat again, shaking.

"You see, he was here all along, the nurse said, and lifted the child from the cot. She had her by the armpits, as if she'd just pulled her out of a birth canal. "She looks different, I said.

"He's fine.

"It's a girl, I said.

"No, I think not, she replied, and undid the nappy so that I could see my daughter's penis and scrotum. "I've already got two boys, I said.

"You'll have your hands full, she said, now on her way out. "Use the call bell if you need anything. Try to get some sleep. And don't forget your liquids. The room was blue. Yet the long white curtains seemed to glow with a sinister light, like two cylinders of glass filled with bleach. Gradually, the morning emerged outside the window. It was May. Birds began to sing, so I knew it was around 4 a.m. The child stirred, sniffing the room like a small animal. She'd soaked her diaper and as I changed her I tried to avoid looking at her strange little girl-penis.

"There's a nub, you see, the midwife had said during the ultrasound scan when I was pregnant with my first son. I put the baby to my breast. My milk still hadn't come in. She sucked eagerly, a few drops of colostrum. It hurt. It was a dry pain. Like sex when you're not wet. She fell asleep at the breast and I sat with her like that. The white curtains poured more and more of their bleach onto us. Outside, the trimmed hedges looked like a stupid poster. Once she was sleeping soundly enough I put her back in the cot. As I straightened up, the blood ran again; I felt it trickle down my leg. With some difficulty I cleaned myself up, using the handheld showerhead, and changed my sanitary towel. My hospital clothes were stained. I felt thirsty again.

In the kitchen I drained the carton of juice in a single gulp. A woman appeared in the doorway.

"Did you see my kid? "No, I told you, I said.

She went back out into the corridor. I went after her.

Now I counted four women in hospital clothes, all with the same ponderous postnatal gait.

I didn't want to go in and see to my child. The strangeness of what the diaper hid frightened me. I decided I'd go along to the duty room and say hi. With meticulous steps I approached. But there was no one there. I looked back down the corridor. It was quite a way to my room. Then the door opener buzzed at the entrance to the ward. I turned to see the door sweep open and one of the messy-haired women pass through it as if in slow motion.

"Hey! I said. "You're not supposed to go out!

I set off after her. I wanted to catch up with her. As I reached the door, another woman in a hospital gown appeared, bewildered-looking.

"Did you see where she went? I asked. She shook her head.

"She's not allowed out there—we must go after her.

She came with me.

We were in a big corridor now. There was no one else around. But we could see her in the distance. At strange zombie speed, with strange zombie steps, we went in pursuit. I could feel myself bleeding again. I was thirsty. There was such a strange light. The light of windowless hospital corridors.

When I was taken upstairs from the delivery room back to my own room, the porter had told me that I'd given birth in a part of the hospital that was built during the Cold War. I hadn't known that I'd given birth underground. But there were several floors down there that had been constructed to withstand a nuclear blast.

The woman we were chasing threw open a door and went through it. We kept going after her. My sidekick groaned softly. We entered another long corridor. It, too, was empty, though narrow and winding. The paint was flaking off the walls like skin. We came to another door, this one held ajar by a bucket. My fellow-pursuer slipped through the crack, and I followed, taking the bucket with me so that the door could close. We were out among the weird shrubs now. The messy-haired woman was still ahead of us. Between the low hedges I saw several other women, bandy-legged, in the same hospital gowns, their laborious way of walking revealing that they, too, had just given birth. We followed.

We came to a tall gable end of the hospital where the others had gathered. The bucket was heavy and the thin metal handle dug into my fingers. I realized now that the bucket was filled with a dull, white liquid, and I put it down. Other buckets also containing milk of lime had been put down all around us. The other women had already started, so we picked up brushes, some of which had long handles, others short, and began whitewashing the wall.

The gable end we were working on was enormous, with a single window high up the wall. Scrupulously we worked, the milk of lime splashing our faces. We bent over our buckets and huffed. Blood ran down our legs, soaking our saggy hospital socks and mingling with the white liquid on the ground. The red and the white couldn't agree, wouldn't mix, but wove together in long marbly rivulets. A strange fog came down around the gable end, whose maintenance was our responsibility.

The work made me dizzy. More than once I staggered, wiped the sweat from my brow. I fell, and was covered in the slimy milk of lime and blood. My face got wet. One of the others reached out to help.

"Did you see my kid? It was the woman from the kitchen.

All of a sudden I thought about my husband at home, the boys. I saw in my mind the unholy mess of their untidied rooms. A monstrous clutter of primary colors.

"Come with me, I said, grasping the woman's hand. I was tired. The alkaline milk of lime stung my skin. It occurred to me that whatever I did I mustn't lick my lips. We went back to the maternity ward without speaking. I showed her into my room.

"Here he is, I said, rolling the cot forward.

She was so remarkably clean. Not a single splash on her, of lime or blood. The child in the cot opened its dark eyes and looked at us. The woman picked him up and kissed him softly.

"He's lovely, but he's not mine. Mine's a girl. "Mine, too, I said.

We looked at the boy. He sneezed.

Smiling, the woman placed him in the dirty-laundry bag.

We sat down. She on the bed. Me on a chair.

Time passed. Sunlight spilled in. We were waiting for him to start crying. It struck me that his skin required lotion. That he was surely dry on the outside, and inside, too. The door opened and a porter came in. He emptied the waste bin, gathered up the laundry bag, and took it away.

The woman beamed from the bed.

"I'm very tired, I said. We fell asleep. "You've lost a lot more blood than we're happy with, the doctor said, but released us nevertheless. The corridor was empty as we left. My husband drove the car. When we got to the house, I went straight upstairs for something to drink. The kitchen looked unchanged. My husband came in, carrying the child in the car seat, and I looked at him in fright. But he hadn't noticed anything, he didn't know the child and couldn't see it was the wrong one.

There was a strange sound, a gasp as I searched myself for the right feeling, but it was like clutching running water, and I realized then that I was laughing.

Every year, when May comes around, I wake up at about 4 a.m., confused by the light of the sky, as if the spring night concealed a day. The trees blossom in the street and I look at them through the window. I am an implement, a sweeping brush, who remembers the other child. It's like happiness.

-----The End-----